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From the editor-in-chief

Well, I for one heaved a sigh of relief. Election 2009 delivered a near-clear mandate for one of the national parties and not a dog's breakfast which many were fearing. The UP's seat score has exceeded all expectations where it needs, perhaps, only the Samajwadi Party and, if it wants, Lalu's RJD, to have a majority.

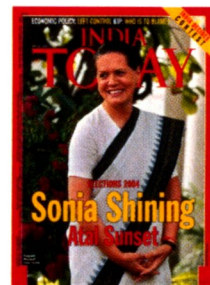
As in every election, there are lessons for politicians every time but above all 2009 shows a certain maturing of the Indian electorate. After returning the 24-party NDA government in 1999 and the last UP government in 2004, a patchwork of 12 parties, the 2009 coalition will have possibly no more than six parties. It has turned out to be one of the most remarkable elections. For the first time since 1967 an incumbent government has been re-elected into office without any emotive issue like a war (1971, 1999) or the assassination of a prime minister (1984). I believe the combination of the clean image of Congress prime ministerial candidate Manmohan Singh and the suddenly energised Rahul Gandhi did the trick. They also cashed in on the successful implementation of the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act and Rs 60,000-crore loan waiver scheme.

The anti-incumbency factor turned out to be no factor at all. People ignored rhetoric, judged candidates on performance (or lack of it) and cast their vote. It also happened at the assembly level. Orissa Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik was returned with a thumping two-thirds majority. In Andhra Pradesh, the ruling party ended up as the largest bloc in the Assembly. Tamil Nadu, which normally swings between extremes, had votes split between the DMK and AIADMK. Delhi was a clean sweep for the ruling party. This was aided, unintentionally of course, by the shambolic BJP which won far less seats than in 2004. They had a leader all right but internal dissension and an unclear message didn't help. It was their election to win but they messed it up.

Most gratifying was the puncturing of the preening egos of the many prime ministerial hopefuls whose pre-result posturing now makes them look quite ludicrous. Uttar Pradesh supremo Mayawati should realise that building statues and flaunting wealth is no substitute for good governance. Tamil Nadu's diva Jayalalithaa would appreciate that somersaults on the LTTE didn't work and Ram Vilas Paswan's casteist politics made him come an embarrassing third. And his fellow caste-meister Lalu Prasad got the drubbing of his life. The Bihar electorate, having tasted governance after 10 years, finally saw through his antics. There could be no better victory in Indian politics than that of performance over caste.

The icing on the cake was the Left being consigned to the dustbin (and hopefully it will stay there), with their presence at the Centre down to a third of their 2004 tally of 61, their worst performance since Independence. Now there is no possibility of the Left exercising proxy power or force-feeding an outdated ideology to the government like they did for five years.

The elections to the 15th Lok Sabha have been long and noisy but their verdict has come swiftly and silenced us all. It reminds us once again that the average Indian may be faceless, forgotten and poor for most part, but when inside a voting booth, he knows just how to make the most of his brief moment of power.



OUR MAY 2004 COVER

(Aroon Purie)



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